

RIE2030 *(with effect from 1 July 2026)*

**INTUITIVE GAP FUND
GRANT SCHEME
DETAILED GUIDELINES FOR APPLICANTS**

1 Objectives

- 1.1. The NTUitive Gap Fund grant scheme will provide funding for beyond proof-of-concept¹ development to researchers in NTU, so as to facilitate the commercialisation of technology developed here in NTU.

2 Overview of NTUitive Gap Fund Grant Scheme

- 2.1. The NTUitive Gap Fund grant will be awarded through a competitive application process to support projects which are technically sound and commercially viable. The work must be conducted in NTU, and should yield results pertaining to viability for commercialisation.
- 2.2. Applicants awarded the grant will receive up to S\$250,000 for the project, which should span no more than 18 months. The actual amount awarded will depend on the extent of work to be carried out.

3 Eligibility

- 3.1. Only staff, postgraduates and researchers from NTU is eligible to apply for the Gap Fund. For each research team, there should be a lead Principal Investigator (lead-PI) to head the team. Full-time PhD students at NTU must first confirm that their scholarship terms permit participation in this POC project and that they will remain enrolled at NTU until its completion. They may then serve as lead-PI of the project, with the project account held in the supervisor's name and the School/Institute ensuring the student receives the supervisor's support in hiring research manpower and accessing the facilities and resources needed for completion.
- 3.2. Lead-PIs with ongoing NTUitive Gap Fund projects should complete their current projects before applying for a new gap fund grant.
- 3.3. While project teams may include collaborators from private sector companies, NTUitive will only support the developmental work conducted in NTU. In particular, only manpower, equipment and operating expenditure incurred at NTU may be charged to the Gap Fund.

4 Application and Call Processes

- 4.1. To apply for Gap Fund, applicants will first need to submit their proposals by filling up the Gap Fund application form.
- 4.2. On announcement of the Gap Fund grant call opening, researchers can submit their applications to gap_fund@ntu.edu.sg.

¹ In general, Gap Fund projects should seek to validate the use of a technology in the context of a specified commercial application.

- 4.3. Proposals submitted should contain all relevant information required for a proper and complete evaluation of their merits without the need to revert to applicants for additional information. Relevant privileged or confidential information should be disclosed if necessary to help convey a better understanding of the proposed project. However, such information should be clearly marked as such in the proposal.
- 4.4. All applicants must comply with the relevant ethics and other regulatory approval requirements needed to carry out their project, as per NTU's policies and regulations.
- 4.6. **Evaluation and endorsement by NTUitive.** NTUitive will evaluate the proposal for technical soundness and commercial viability, in line with the guidelines in Annex B.
- 4.7. Only those proposals which satisfy the guidelines will be endorsed by NTUitive. Please note that only proposals which have been endorsed by NTUitive will be submitted to the Gap Fund evaluation panel.
- 4.8. **Evaluation by External Panel and award of grant.** The Gap Fund evaluation panel will convene to assess the proposals that have been endorsed by NTUitive and make recommendations on those to be awarded the Gap Fund grant, based on the selection criteria listed in Annex B. Following recommendation by the panel and venture build team, NTUitive will inform the successful applicants.
- 4.9. **Finality of decision.** Any decision made by NTUitive and the External Panel shall be final and conclusive.

5 Training, Progress Reports and Presentations

- 5.1. All awarded project teams are required to submit interim progress reports every 6 months to NTUitive. Such reports are due on the 7th and 13th month for a project spanning 18 months. The project teams are also required to give a project progress presentation to NTUitive at the same time that they submit the progress reports. Final technical reports on the overall technical achievements and commercialisation efforts of completed projects must be submitted to the NTUitive within 3 months of project completion. Every project team may be invited to deliver an end of project presentation to the Gap Fund evaluation panel after they submit the final technical report. These reports are to follow the templates provided by NTUitive. NTUitive reserves the right to request for progress reports more frequently when necessary.
- 5.2. The Lead PI may be invited to participate in the National Graduate Research Innovation Programme (GRIP) prior to the completion of the project. National GRIP is a deep-tech venture-building programme that supports researchers in translating research outcomes into market-ready startups through structured entrepreneurial training, expert mentorship and commercialisation support.

6 Intellectual Property Management

- 6.1. Applicants agree to be bound by NTU's policies on Intellectual Property (IP), Technology Transfer and Research Collaboration as may be in force at the material times. In the event Applicants require the services of external (that is, non NTU) collaborators, Applicants shall ensure that the relevant IP arrangements are in place to clearly define the rights and obligations of Applicants and the external collaborators.

7 Funding Support

- 7.1. Under the Gap Fund scheme, NTUitive offers funding support of up to S\$250,000 per project over the maximum duration of 18 months. The total cost of the project includes only approved direct costs, which are defined as the incremental cost required in executing the project. This excludes contributions in-kind, existing equipment and the cost of existing manpower as well as building cost. All expenditures should be budgeted inclusive of any applicable Goods and Services Taxes (GST) at the prevailing rates.
- 7.2. Any direct cost charged to the POC grant must be reasonable and for the proposed developmental activities of the project. Supportable direct costs can be classified into the following three cost categories:
- i. Expenditure on manpower (EOM);
 - ii. Expenditure on equipment;
 - iii. Other operating expenditure (OOE).
- 7.3. NTUitive will support 100 percent of the approved direct cost for projects from NTU. For projects involving private sector participants, the Gap Fund grant will only fund the portion of the developmental work conducted in the NTU (i.e. only manpower, equipment and operating expenditures incurred in NTU may be charged to the grant).
- 7.4. Please refer to Annex A for a detailed guide on non-fundable cost items. NTUitive's decision on the funding support to be awarded for each project is final.

8 Changes to Guidelines

- 8.1. NTUitive reserves the right to make changes to the above guidelines and any submission templates related to the Gap Fund scheme, as and when it deems fit.

Annex A: NTUitive Gap Fund – List of Non-Fundable Items

1. This annex specifies the items and categories of expenditure that are non-fundable by NTUitive Gap Fund.
2. The following general policies apply:
 - Procurement and expenditures for all items are subject to the formal established financial policies of NTU that are consistently applied, regardless of the source of funds.
 - Fractional charging for staff costs based on time commitment to the project must be practised.
 - The funding covers Government Service Tax (GST), customs duties/taxes and/or fees, and bank charges incurred in specific relation to the procurement of fundable items.

Type of Expenses	Description
Salaries of Programme Director/ Lead Principal Investigators/ Project Leads and Investigators	Not allowable, salaries for Programme Director/ Lead Principal Investigators/ Project Leads and Investigators are typically funded by their employing institutions or from the institutional budget or capitation grants. Charging these salaries to grants would result in double-dipping.
Salaries of teaching staff and teaching substitutes	Teaching duties are part of the institution's normal operations and are funded through institutional budgets or capitation grants. This does not include Backfilling – manpower cost for staff hired to offload teaching duties of Principal Investigators / Co-Investigators to do project work (fractional charges based on time committed).
Undergraduate tuition support	Tuition fees are educational expenses, not costs that directly contribute to the IDF Gap Project's deliverables or outcomes.
Salaries of general administrative staff	General administrative staff (e.g. human resource, finance, procurement, research support office etc) provide institutional support services and their salaries are part of the institution's operating expenses, which are typically funded through indirect costs or the institutional budget. In addition, these are not costs that directly contribute to the IDF Gap Project's deliverables or outcomes.
Salaries of visiting professors, researchers and collaborators	Their salaries should be funded by their home institutions.

Costs related to general administration and management	These costs cover broad institutional functions such as human resource, procurement, and governance, which are not specific to the IDF Gap Project. Such costs are part of the institution's operating expenses, typically funded through indirect cost or other internal budgets. Such costs include common office equipment, such as furniture and fittings, office software ¹ , photocopiers, scanners and office supplies.
Costs of office or laboratory space	This is an indirect cost that should be funded from other funding sources. Such costs include renovation/outfitting costs, rent, depreciation of buildings and equipment, and related expenditures such as water, electricity, general waste disposal and building/facilities maintenance charges.
Personal productivity tools & communication expenses	Not allowable, unless the use of mobile phones and other form of smart devices were indicated in the methodology for the IDF Gap Project.
Costs of Entertainment	Such expenses (e.g. meals, social events) are discretionary and do not advance the objectives of the IDF Gap Project.
Costs of Refreshments	Not allowable, unless this is related to a hosted conference or workshop for the IDF Gap Project.
Audit fees (Internal and external audit) and Legal fees	This is an indirect cost that should be funded from other funding sources.
Costs for staff retreats and team-building activities	These are discretionary costs that are unrelated to the IDF Gap Project's deliverables.
Professional Membership Fees	Such costs are institutional or personal development expenses and are not directly tied to the IDF Gap Project's objectives or deliverables.
Fines and Penalties	These costs arise from negligence and non-compliance by the institution or individual, not from the IDF Gap Project's activities. Such costs should be borne by the party responsible for the infraction.
Costs of Patent Application	Not allowable, as this should be supported from the IDF Core Funding allocated to the I&E Office, which supports patent application filing, maintenance and other related costs.

¹ This is defined as the basic set of office software, such as the Microsoft suite of applications.

ANNEX B: EVALUATION CRITERIA FOR NTUITIVE

NTUitive will evaluate the submitted proposals based on the following criteria:

Criteria	Guiding Questions
Technical Innovation (55%)	• Technical Differentiation: Is it faster, cheaper, better? Is it a Me-too, Enhancer, or Disrupter? • Technical Landscape: Are competing technologies well understood? • Strength of IP: Is the technology defensible, or not encumbered? • Technical scalability/manufacturability: Can it be engineered/deployed at scale? • Technical Readiness: Is it too early, POC ready, or ripe for commercial prototype?
Value Proposition (25%)	• Is the problem statement well defined and scoped? • Is the pain point clearly articulated and significant: frequent, prevalent, expensive? • Does the product offer a unique solution? Does it solve pain points effectively/uniquely?
Market Opportunity (20%)	• Is the addressable market(s) large, clearly identified and within reach? • What is the market growth rate?